

AN SE-YOUNG IS RUNNING OUT OF OPPONENTS

At the India Open in New Delhi, An Se-young did not just win another title. She **dismantled** what remained of meaningful resistance in women's singles.

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A few minutes after she had won her quarterfinal match at the India Open, Thailand's Ratchanok Intanon was asked how she would be preparing for a potential semifinal against South Korea's An Se-young.

What kind of homework and research would Ratchanok, considered one of the most graceful and skilled women's singles players of all time, be doing against a player she had faced 14 times since their first encounter in 2019? What sort of weakness would she be looking to exploit?

Ratchanok burst out giggling as she registered the question.

"Weakness? I don't know what her weakness is right now!"

There have been more stylish players. There have been players with more varied strokes who thrive on the excitement of attack.

But none has been as dominant as the 23-year-old Korean. Last year, An, the reigning Olympic champion, entered 15 tournaments on the World Tour, reached 12 finals and won 11. Only 18 singles players have earned over a million dollars in prize money in their careers. An earned that in a single season. She recorded only four losses over the course of the year and won 94.8 per cent of the matches she played, exceeding the win rates of the

legendary men's singles players Lee Chong Wei and Lin Dan at the peak of their careers.

In 2026, she picked up right where she left off, winning the season opener in Malaysia. At the India Open, she blitzed past the field to reach the final once again.

Former world champion Nozomi Okuhara, Chinese Taipei's Huang Yu-Hsun and 2025 world bronze medallist Putri Kusuma Wardani were ousted in straight games, none of them even making it to double digits in the second set. In the semifinals, it was former world champion Ratchanok's turn to be out of ideas. The Thai lost 21-11, 21-7 in a little over half an hour. It was the 13th straight time that Ratchanok had lost to An.

In the final, An was up against world No. 2 Wang Zhiyi. The Chinese shuttler at least managed a partial win in that she made it, admittedly barely, to double digits in the second game before losing 21-13, 21-11.

There was a sense of inevitability to it, encapsulated by a pithy remark on social media. It went something like this: badminton women's singles